served as one of the five permanent members of the Security Council, until the People's Republic of China occupied China's seat in 1971.

Mongolia had undergone some important changes since the declaration of independence in 1911. The old clerical state ceased to exist when the Russian Red Army occupied the country in 1921. The invasion had been prompted by the reign of terror that a former major-general in the Tsar's army had unleashed in the Russian Far East and adjoining areas. His name was Roman Fyodorovich von Ungern-Sternberg and he would today have been certified as a psychopath and locked up. Known as 'the Mad Baron', he had adopted Lamaistic Buddhism from Mongol horsemen in his cavalry unit. His Buddhist teachers had taught him about reincarnation, and he firmly believed that in killing feeble people he only did them good, as they would be stronger in their next life.

In the autumn of 1920, von Ungern-Sternberg led a motley force of 6,000 former members of the Tsar's cavalry, local Cossacks, and Mongol horsemen into Mongolia. When they invaded Urga in January 1921, 'innumerable children of all ages, races and creeds were hacked to bits and bayoneted and shot and strangled and hung, and crucified and buried alive'.[54]

In Mongolia, von Ungern-Sternberg proclaimed himself 'Emperor of all Russia' and vowed to plant ' an avenue of gallows' stretching from Urga to Moscow, from which would swing 'Bolshevik and Jew alike'.[55] He also declared that he would lead his men all the way to Tibet, where, he believed, his 'empire' would forge a pact with the Dalai Lama.

The new Bolshevik government in Moscow clearly viewed the Mad Baron as a threat, and not only because of the atrocities he committed. Von Ungern-Sternberg's main benefactors were the Japanese, who saw him as a useful tool to expand their influence in north-central Asia, especially after their victory in the 1904–5 war against Tsarist Russia. The Japanese openly backed von Ungern-Sternberg's plans for a 'Greater Mongolia', which they had already earmarked as their own protectorate. It is uncertain whether a conquest of Tibet was also part of the plan, but von Ungern-Sternberg's Japanese-backed rampage in the region was cause for concern in New Delhi and London, emphasizing the need to secure the northern borders of British India.